

Jothi Tutor Academy

Mentor Handbook

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Practical guide for use alongside the formal JTA documents, SKOOL, NotebookLM, and the portal.

This handbook is a practical route through the JTA system. The formal JF, JTS, and JTD documents remain the source of truth.

Version 1.0 | Internal working release

How to use the JTA learning system

Channel	Role
Formal documents	Source of truth
Handbook	Practical route
SKOOL	Paced pathway
NotebookLM	Clarification and recap
Portal	Access hub

Use this handbook for day-to-day action. Use the formal documents when you need the exact standard, threshold, or rule. Mentors should also read the Tutor Handbook so they understand the tutor-facing route through the same system.

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Chapter 1 — Purpose of Mentoring in JTA

Purpose: Define mentoring properly so it does not collapse into casual supervision or vague encouragement.

Mentoring in JTA is a quality role. Mentors do more than watch lessons and offer general impressions. They shape tutor development, protect the standard, judge evidence carefully, and help the academy scale without diluting teaching quality.

A strong mentor helps tutors improve faster because the feedback is specific, the standards are clear, and the progression decisions are evidence-based. A weak mentor weakens not only one tutor but the academy's whole development system.

Use this handbook as the practical operating guide for mentoring. Use the formal documents when you need the exact standard, evidence threshold, or certification rule.

What this means in practice

Your job is not to make the tutor feel comfortable at any cost. Your job is to help the tutor improve while protecting the quality of teaching students receive.

Chapter 2 — The Mentor Role in the JTA System

Purpose: Show the whole mentor role clearly so mentoring is not reduced to observation alone.

Mentor responsibility	What it looks like in practice
Observe	Watch teaching through the 4T lens and record usable evidence.
Coach	Set one clear development target and explain why it matters.

Mentor responsibility	What it looks like in practice
Review reflection	Read tutor reflections before debriefs and before later observations.
Judge evidence	Separate one strong moment from repeated, credible performance.
Sign off	Record competency evidence only where the standard has genuinely been met.
Calibrate	Compare judgement with other mentors and resolve drift.
Contribute to panel decisions	Bring accurate evidence and honest professional judgement to progression and certification decisions.
Escalate	Raise safeguarding, conduct, or system risks through the correct route.

Mentoring is not vague reassurance, performance management, or repeated rescue. It is structured development. Where mentors are too soft, the standard drifts. Where mentors are too harsh or inconsistent, trust breaks and honest reflection collapses.

What this means in practice

Carry the full role. Observation without coaching is incomplete. Coaching without evidence is weak. Sign-off without calibration is unsafe.

Chapter 3 — The Architecture Mentors Must Hold

Purpose: Give mentors one shared systems map so coaching does not drift into personal preference.

Layer	What it does	How mentors use it
Jothi Trifecta	Defines the conditions for durable learning.	Diagnose whether a problem is strategic, mindset-related, or environmental.
4T Teaching Engine	Defines the lesson cycle used in observation and coaching.	Structure live lesson noticing and feedback.
Teaching Standards	Define what good practice looks like operationally.	Anchor observations in shared expectations.
Competency Framework	Defines the 22 competencies across A–F domains.	Name evidence precisely and support sign-off decisions.
Residency Pathway	Defines stage expectations and	Judge readiness with the right stage lens.

Layer	What it does	How mentors use it
	progression gates.	
Reflection / Observation / Dashboard / Certification	Creates the evidence cycle across lessons and across time.	Review patterns, not just isolated lessons.

Mentors are the bridge between the formal standard and the tutor's live practice. When mentors hold the architecture well, tutors receive one coherent system. When mentors improvise outside it, the system fragments quickly.

What this means in practice

Coach through shared standards, not through habit, memory, or personal teaching preference.

Chapter 4 — Residency Stages and What Mentors Expect

Purpose: Make stage expectations concrete and reduce drift between mentors.

Stage	Tutor scope	Mentor focus	Common mistaken judgement
Observation	The tutor watches and reflects. No competency sign-off is expected here.	Active noticing of teaching moves, accurate use of 4T language, honest reflection, and purposeful debrief questions.	Treating passive watching as enough; expecting live teaching evidence too early.
Co-Teaching	The tutor leads short planned sections with mentor support present.	JCT1 only. Look especially for C1, C2, C3, F2, F3, and F4. The tutor should attempt real teaching, not only easy recap.	Assessing JCT2 or JCT3 too early or rescuing so quickly that evidence never appears.
Lead Teaching	The tutor holds progressively longer lessons under observation.	JCT1 should consolidate and JCT2 should begin to emerge. By the end of the stage, JCT1 should feel consistent, not occasional.	Moving tutors on because the calendar says so, rather than because the evidence supports it.
Independent Teaching	The tutor holds a six-week teaching cycle with continued oversight.	JCT2 should strengthen across time and JCT3 should begin to appear. Assessment use and progress tracking now matter much more.	Judging from one strong lesson rather than the pattern across the cycle.
Certification	The tutor closes remaining evidence gaps before panel	Specific final evidence, completed readiness pack, and clean panel	Repeating work already evidenced instead of

Stage	Tutor scope	Mentor focus	Common mistaken judgement
Runway	review.	visibility.	targeting the actual remaining gap.

Stage expectations and competency levels are related but not identical. A tutor may be in Lead Teaching and still need more evidence in a JCT1 area. Mentors should address that directly instead of assuming stage entry equals competency completion.

What this means in practice

Use the right expectation for the right stage. A good mentor protects tutors from being pushed too early and protects students from premature progression.

Chapter 5 — Observing Through the 4T Lens

Purpose: Standardise what mentors notice in live lessons so observations are specific and comparable.

4T phase	What to look for	Strong evidence	Weak practice
Teach	Clarity, sequencing, visible reasoning, and manageable pace.	The student can follow why each step follows from the previous one.	The tutor sounds fluent but the logic is hidden or rushed.
Test	Questions that reveal reasoning rather than surface compliance.	A question exposes how the student is thinking and changes what the tutor does next.	The tutor uses “Do you understand?” or recall-only questions.
Track	Noticing written evidence, hesitation, patterns, and guessing.	The mentor can point to the exact moment confusion surfaced.	The tutor monitors right/wrong only.
Transform	Rebuilding the source of error rather than patching the answer.	The student understands the corrected reasoning and can re-apply it.	The tutor supplies the answer and moves on.

Good observation records concrete moments: the question asked, the student response, the hesitation point, the board step skipped, or the correction move chosen. General praise without such detail does not help later judgement or later mentoring.

What this means in practice

Record what happened, not only what you felt about it.

Chapter 6 — Using JTD04 Well

Purpose: Help mentors complete the observation form in a way that produces reliable, reusable evidence.

JTD04 section	What it captures	What good completion looks like
Lesson Context	Who, when, what, and where in the pathway.	The role and stage match the tutor's real position in the residency.
4T Rating	Judgement on Teach, Test, Track, Transform.	Each rating can be justified from specific lesson behaviour.
JCT1 Ratings	Core competency visibility in the lesson.	Ratings are honest, with N/O used sparingly and only when justified.
Focus Competency	The main competency being watched in that observation.	The chosen competency matches the tutor's stage and is supported by a specific evidence note.
Mentor Evaluation	Overall confidence, sign-off signal, and one improvement target.	The target is specific enough to be tried in the next lesson.
Sign-Off Note	Formal evidence for a competency decision where warranted.	The competency named is exactly the one evidenced, with a clear moment or timestamp.

Stage alignment matters. In Co-Teaching, the focus competency should be JCT1 only. In Lead Teaching and Independent Teaching, the focus should match the expectations of that stage rather than jump ahead because a tutor seems enthusiastic or polished.

For the full evidence-quality standard and sign-off judgement rules, see Chapter 8

What this means in practice

A good JTD04 record should stand on its own. Another mentor should be able to read it later and understand what was seen, what was judged, and why.

Chapter 7 — Giving Better Debriefs

Purpose: Sharpen mentor feedback so it drives change rather than creating fog.

A good debrief does three things: names one real strength, identifies one main improvement target, and makes the next step immediately usable. Debriefs become weak when they are vague, overloaded, or framed as personal preference.

Weak feedback	Stronger feedback
“Good lesson. Keep going.”	“Your explanation stayed clear and stepwise, but you moved on after correct answers without checking the reasoning.”
“Improve questioning.”	“After each worked example, pause and ask the student to predict what changes if one value changes.”
Three to five improvement targets at once	One main target with one clear lesson action

Strong targets are specific enough to attempt in the next lesson. They describe a teaching move, not a vague aspiration. They also connect clearly to a competency so the tutor understands why the target matters.

What this means in practice

If the tutor cannot act on your target in the next lesson, the target is still too broad.

Chapter 8 — Competency Judgement and Evidence Quality

Purpose: Standardise sign-off thinking so competencies are judged on evidence rather than optimism.

Mentors should judge evidence proportionately. JCT1 requires strong core habits that should become consistent by the end of Lead Teaching. JCT2 reflects stronger instructional judgement. JCT3 should emerge across time and across a teaching cycle, not as a single isolated flourish.

Strong evidence	Weak evidence
Repeated, specific observation notes across multiple lessons	One strong lesson with no pattern behind it
Direct observation or recording review tied to a competency	Tutor self-report alone
Evidence that survives mentor scrutiny and calibration	General confidence in the tutor

Strong evidence	Weak evidence
A sign-off note that names the exact competency and exact behaviour	A sign-off based on broad positive impression

Sign-off is not a gesture of encouragement. It is a quality judgement. Equally, holding sign-off back when the evidence is genuinely sufficient is also poor practice. Mentors must be evidence-first and proportionately firm.

What this means in practice

Sign off evidence, not hope.

Chapter 9 — Calibration and Mentor Consistency

Purpose: Protect the standard as the academy scales and avoid mentor drift.

Calibration exists because no single mentor should become the entire source of truth. A second mentor helps check whether the original judgement is proportionate, whether the evidence is strong enough, and whether the standard is being applied consistently across tutors.

Calibration step	What happens
Primary mentor observes	Initial evidence is gathered and recorded.
Second mentor observes	An independent view is added, usually in Independent Teaching or where judgement is borderline.
Evidence is compared	Agreement or divergence is made explicit rather than assumed.
Differences are discussed	Mentors identify whether the issue is evidence quality, interpretation, or expectation drift.
Panel uses the evidence	The mentor panel takes the combined picture into progression or certification decisions where required.

- Calibration should not be treated as mistrust; it is part of quality protection.
- Unspoken disagreement is dangerous. It creates silent drift and weakens later panel decisions.
- A mentor who is consistently too lenient or too strict should be recalibrated rather than left to shape the system alone.

What this means in practice

Ask yourself: would another well-calibrated mentor reach a similar judgement from the evidence I have recorded?

Chapter 10 — Progression Gates

Purpose: Make stage movement evidence-based and consistent across mentors.

Gate	Evidence reviewed	Readiness signals	Hold if...
Observation → Co-Teaching	Observation reflections and mentor confirmation	The tutor notices teaching moves rather than topic coverage.	Observation is passive or reflections are thin.
Co-Teaching → Lead Teaching	Observation records, reflections, and response to feedback	Early JCT1 behaviours are appearing and the tutor can hold short sections deliberately.	The tutor remains unreliable, defensive, or structurally weak.
Lead Teaching → Independent Teaching	All lead-teaching records, JCT1 status, and JCT2 emergence	JCT1 is consistent and lesson quality is holding across longer durations.	The standard is still one-off or fragile.
Independent Teaching → Certification Runway	Cycle evidence, reflections, mentor observations, calibration, progress evidence	Quality is stable across time and the remaining gaps are specific and manageable.	The cycle evidence is uneven or key areas remain unevidenced.

Minimum observation requirements across the residency

2 JTD04 records from Co-Teaching.

4 JTD04 records from Lead Teaching.

Minimum 2 JTD04 records from Independent Teaching, of which at least 1 must be a second-mentor calibration observation.

Total minimum: 8 mentor observations.

These are minimum requirements, not progression guarantees. Evidence quality matters as much as the count. See JTD03 and JTD06 for the full gate criteria.

What this means in practice

The right question is not, 'Have they done enough weeks?' It is, 'Does the evidence support the next level of responsibility?'

Chapter 11 — Certification and Sign-Off

Purpose: Clarify the final decision stage so mentors protect the standard without creating avoidable ambiguity.

Sign-off happens throughout the residency as competency evidence accumulates. Certification happens once, at the end of the Certification Runway, when the mentor panel judges the full readiness pack.

Decision area	Practical mentor task
Sign-off	Record only stage-appropriate, repeated, credible evidence for a named competency.
Readiness pack	Ensure records, reflections, calibration, and required evidence items are complete before panel review.
Panel review	Bring your actual judgement, not only the mood of the room or the preference of the primary mentor.
Outcome communication	Ensure the tutor receives a clear outcome, clear reasons, and clear next steps.
Recording	Make sure sign-offs and decisions are reflected in the dashboard and tutor records.

Possible outcome	Meaning
Certified	Thresholds are met and the panel has confidence in sustained readiness.
Certified with Development Targets	Certification is confirmed but some areas remain named priorities.
Extended Runway	The tutor is close but still has specific, addressable evidence gaps.
Not Yet Certified	The evidence is insufficient or unconvincing and more development is required.

What this means in practice

If a certification decision had to be defended later, the evidence should already be strong enough to defend it.

Chapter 12 — Operational Mentor Routines

Purpose: Turn mentoring into repeatable practice so quality does not depend on memory or improvisation.

Before the lesson

- Know the tutor's stage and the specific focus for the observation.
- Review the previous improvement target and any recent reflection.
- Be clear what you are watching for and why.

During the lesson

- Observe through the 4T lens.
- Note exact moments rather than only global impressions.
- Avoid rescuing too early unless student learning is at serious risk.
- Watch both the tutor's behaviour and the student's response.

After the lesson

- Debrief briefly and clearly.
- Set one specific improvement target.
- Complete the JTD04 record promptly.
- Log sign-off evidence only where warranted.
- Escalate safeguarding or conduct issues immediately through the correct route.

Operationally, mentors should also ensure that form options and cohort-specific operational lists remain current at the start of each new cohort.

Escalate concerns through the approved Jothi route to academy leadership. If the concern involves safeguarding, welfare, serious professional conduct, or a risk that should not wait, escalate immediately rather than waiting for the next mentor discussion.

What this means in practice

Strong mentoring routines make the system stronger. Weak routines force later guesswork, backfilling, and inconsistent decisions.

Chapter 13 — Common Mentor Mistakes

Purpose: Prevent weak mentoring habits from becoming embedded in the system.

Mistake	Why it matters	What to do instead
Vague positive feedback	The tutor cannot act on it.	Name the specific behaviour and why it mattered.
Too many targets	The tutor's attention scatters.	Set one main target per lesson.
Rescuing too quickly	Real evidence never appears.	Let the tutor work through manageable difficulty.
Signing off after one strong lesson	Pattern is mistaken for moment.	Wait for repeated, credible evidence.
Confusing confidence with competence	Polish hides weakness.	Judge what the tutor did, not how fluent they sounded.
Progressing under staffing pressure	Students pay for premature movement.	Hold the gate until the evidence supports it.
Ignoring tutor reflections	The development loop weakens.	Read them and use them in debrief and later observations.
Not prompting the school context check	A4 is a JCT1 competency. If the tutor is not checking what the student's school is currently covering, upcoming tests, or immediate priorities, lesson focus can drift away from what the student actually needs.	Prompt the school context check in co-planning and debrief. If it is missing in the lesson, name it directly and make it an explicit target for the next session.

What this means in practice

A mentor can damage quality by being too soft, too vague, too fast, or too inconsistent. The goal is not strictness for its own sake. The goal is accurate judgement.

Chapter 14 — Using the Wider Learning System Without Overwhelm

Purpose: Make mentors guardians of the non-competing route model so tutors are helped, not overloaded.

JTA uses multiple representations on purpose, but those representations should not compete. Formal documents hold the standard. The handbook gives the practical route. SKOOL gives the pathway. NotebookLM is built to help you ask plain-language questions about the JTA system, get a recap of a document, or clarify a term quickly. It supports the formal documents; it does not replace them. The portal gives access.

Tutor needs...	Direct them to...
The exact standard, threshold, or rule	Formal document
A practical explanation of what to do now	Handbook
The next page, sequence, or task	SKOOL
A quick recap or plain-language explanation	NotebookLM
The official file or link	Portal
Lesson-specific or evidence-specific guidance	Mentor conversation

Do not send tutors to four places for the same answer. Good signposting reduces choice friction. Poor signposting makes support feel like burden.

What this means in practice

Your job is not only to mentor the tutor. It is also to guide the tutor to the right route through the learning system so the channels support rather than compete with each other.